



CANDY



It doesn't have to be Valentine's Day for candy lovers and chocoholics to relish sweet tastes. It is estimated that 99% of North American households buy candy at least once a week.

In a word

The word **candy** is derived from the Arabic word *qandi*, meaning "something made with sugar." Sugary treats are known as **confections**, and a **confectioner** is someone who specializes in making sweets.

By definition

Candy is a sweet confection made with sugar, other sweeteners and flavors. Confectionery items include a variety of hard candies, lollipops, candy bars, chocolate, candy floss and other sweet snacks. Desserts such as ice cream, cakes and puddings are not considered confections.

Early sweets

Honey was probably the first sweet snack enjoyed by prehistoric man, and it is likely that he dipped fruit and nuts into honey. We know for sure that the ancient Egyptians (about 3,500 years ago) combined fruits, nuts and honey to make candy. Archaeologists have discovered **marshmallow** (honey that is flavored and thickened with the sap of the marshmallow plant) and **licorice** treats in pharaohs' tombs.

Honey was the sweetener of choice until the discovery of sugar cane, which was first cultivated in ancient China, India and Persia about A.D. 500. Sugar made its way to Europe around A.D. 1100.

Native Americans boiled the sweet sap of the maple tree to make **maple sugar**. In 1519, Spanish explorers in Mexico found **cacao**, from which chocolate is made. Chocolate was first served as a medicinal beverage. The chocolate bar was invented in the late 1870s.

Medicinal uses

Many early sweets were consumed as medical treatments for digestive troubles. Today's cough drop and peppermint stick can be traced back to this tradition. Licorice root mixed with honey or sugar has been used to treat arthritis, asthma, constipation, depression, fatigue and sore throats. Jujubes and marshmallows are other examples of ancient medicines becoming modern candies.



Valentine candy

In 1868, **Richard Cadbury** invented the first Valentine candy box. Decorated with a painting of his daughter and her kitten, this Valentine treat was a great success. The early colonists first made candy hearts by scratching love notes on candy. Today, about 8 billion candy hearts are made each year with the familiar "Be Mine" and "Kiss Me" inscriptions on them.

Did you know?

- One butterscotch disc has 20 calories. Eight gumdrops or jelly beans have 115 calories. These candies have no fat or cholesterol.
- If you brush after snacks, candy will not contribute to tooth decay.
- A cup of candy corn contains fewer calories than a cup of raisins.
- During the four weeks before Christmas, nearly 2 billion candy canes are sold in the United States.
- The Baby Ruth chocolate bar was introduced in 1920. Some say it was named for President Grover Cleveland's daughter; others say it was named for the famous baseball player.
- Cotton candy is also known as "candy floss" or "fairy floss." The first machine for making cotton candy was patented in 1899.
- Many early sweets were consumed as medical treatments.